BIO Web of Conferences **236**, 0100125 (2026) https://doi.org/10.1051/bioconf/20262360100125
FoSET 2025

An IoT-Enabled Digital Twin Framework for Spatiotemporal Modeling and Predictive Optimization of Urban Carbon Emissions Using Graph Neural Networks

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Abstract. Rapid urbanization has intensified carbon emissions, yet existing monitoring frameworks rely on static, retrospective inventories that fail to capture the dynamic spatiotemporal complexity of urban pollution. To address this critical gap in smart city environmental management, this study proposes a novel Internet of Things (IoT)-enabled Digital Twin framework integrated with Graph Neural Networks (GNNs) for real-time spatiotemporal modeling and predictive optimization of urban carbon emissions. The proposed framework integrates heterogeneous IoT sensor networks, capturing CO2, NOx, traffic flow, and meteorological data, alongside satellite imagery into a unified data pipeline processed via edge computing. Within this architecture, a city-scale graph representation was constructed where intersections and emission sources serve as nodes, and road networks and wind corridors function as edges. A Spatiotemporal Graph Convolutional Network (ST-GCN) was subsequently developed to capture non-linear dependencies across space and time, while a reinforcement learning agent was deployed within the Digital Twin environment to simulate and optimize traffic signal coordination and emission reduction strategies.

1 Introduction

The accelerating pace of global urbanization has positioned cities as primary contributors to anthropogenic greenhouse gas emissions, accounting for over seventy percent of global carbon dioxide output. As metropolitan areas expand, the complex interplay between traffic dynamics, industrial activities, energy consumption, and meteorological conditions generates highly non-linear and spatially heterogeneous pollution patterns. Addressing these challenges

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is critical for achieving the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals, particularly SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities) and SDG 13 (Climate Action). Consequently, urban planners and environmental policymakers urgently require advanced computational frameworks capable of capturing the dynamic spatiotemporal evolution of carbon emissions to facilitate evidence-based mitigation strategies and resilient urban management. Historically, urban carbon monitoring has relied on static emission inventories and top-down statistical models that aggregate data on annual or monthly timescales. While useful for long-term policy formulation, these retrospective approaches fail to capture real-time fluctuations driven by transient traffic congestion, localized industrial operations, or microclimatic variations. The deployment of ground-based IoT sensor networks and remote sensing platforms has significantly improved data granularity; however, the resulting high-frequency, multi-source datasets pose substantial computational challenges. Conventional analytical pipelines often process these streams in isolation, neglecting the intrinsic spatial dependencies between monitoring stations and the temporal autocorrelation inherent in atmospheric dispersion processes. This fragmentation limits the ability to generate actionable, short-term forecasts or to simulate the cascading environmental impacts of localized interventions. Recent advancements in artificial intelligence and cyber-physical systems have catalyzed the emergence of Digital Twin paradigms for urban environmental management. By creating high-fidelity virtual replicas of physical infrastructure, Digital Twins enable continuous synchronization, scenario simulation, and predictive analytics. Simultaneously, deep learning architectures, particularly Convolutional Neural Networks and Recurrent Neural Networks, have demonstrated remarkable performance in environmental time-series forecasting. Nevertheless, standard convolutional models struggle to model irregular urban topologies, while recurrent architectures often fail to capture long-range spatial dependencies. Moreover, most existing frameworks operate as passive monitoring systems, lacking integrated decision-support mechanisms that can translate predictive insights into optimized control actions, such as adaptive traffic signal timing or dynamic emission zoning. The computational latency associated with cloud-centric architectures further impedes real-time responsiveness, highlighting the need for edge-assisted, graph-aware modeling approaches. To bridge these methodological and operational gaps, this study introduces a novel IoT-enabled Digital Twin framework that leverages Graph Neural Networks for high-resolution spatiotemporal modeling and predictive optimization of urban carbon emissions. Unlike Euclidean deep learning models, graph-based architectures explicitly encode the non-Euclidean structure of urban environments by representing intersections, emission sources, and monitoring nodes as graph vertices, with road networks, wind corridors, and pollution diffusion pathways serving as edges. This topological representation enables the model to learn complex spatial propagation patterns and temporal dynamics simultaneously. Integrated within a low-latency edge-cloud architecture, the Digital Twin continuously ingests heterogeneous IoT streams and satellite-derived environmental indicators, updating its internal state in near-real time. Furthermore, a reinforcement learning agent is embedded within the simulation environment to autonomously evaluate and optimize traffic flow configurations and emission reduction strategies, transforming the framework from a diagnostic tool into a proactive control system. The primary objective of this research is to develop and empirically validate a scalable computational architecture that enhances the predictive accuracy of urban carbon concentration forecasting while enabling data-driven policy optimization. Specifically, this study evaluates the performance of a Spatiotemporal Graph Convolutional Network against established baseline models, quantifies the latency and throughput benefits of edge-assisted data processing, and demonstrates the efficacy of reinforcement learning-driven traffic signal coordination in mitigating peak-hour emissions. By synthesizing IoT infrastructure, Digital

Twin virtualization, and graph-based deep learning, this work contributes a transferable methodological pipeline for smart city environmental management, offering policymakers a robust mechanism to transition from reactive compliance monitoring to predictive, adaptive carbon governance.

2 Methodology

The methodological framework of this study is structured into four interconnected phases: IoT data acquisition and preprocessing, spatiotemporal graph construction and predictive modeling, Digital Twin environment formulation, and reinforcement learning-based optimization. The empirical validation was conducted using a comprehensive dataset collected over a six-month period (January to June 2024) from a mid-sized European city with a population of approximately 500,000. The IoT infrastructure comprised 150 edge computing nodes deployed at critical traffic intersections, each equipped with non-dispersive infrared (NDIR) CO2 sensors, electrochemical NOx detectors, high-definition traffic cameras for vehicle counting and speed estimation, and localized meteorological stations measuring wind speed, wind direction, temperature, and humidity. To ensure real-time processing capabilities, raw data streams were initially filtered and aggregated at the edge using lightweight anomaly detection algorithms before being transmitted via the MQTT protocol to a centralized cloud platform. Data preprocessing involved temporal synchronization across heterogeneous sensors, missing value imputation using K-nearest neighbors (KNN) interpolation, and min-max normalization to scale all features into a uniform range, ultimately yielding a high-resolution spatiotemporal dataset with a 5-minute temporal granularity.

To capture the complex, non-Euclidean spatial dependencies of the urban environment, the city's road network was mathematically modeled as a directed graph G = (V, E, A), where V represents the set of intersections equipped with IoT nodes, E denotes the road segments connecting these nodes, and A is the weighted adjacency matrix. Unlike traditional approaches that rely solely on topological distance, the adjacency matrix A in this study was dynamically constructed by integrating both physical road connectivity and meteorological spatial correlation; specifically, edge weights were adjusted based on real-time wind vectors to account for the atmospheric dispersion of carbon emissions between adjacent and downwind intersections. For the predictive modeling phase, a Spatiotemporal Graph Convolutional Network (ST-GCN) was developed to forecast future CO2 concentrations. The ST-GCN architecture synergizes Graph Convolutional Networks (GCN) to extract spatial features by aggregating information from neighboring nodes according to the dynamic adjacency matrix, and Gated Recurrent Units (GRU) to capture temporal evolution and long-term dependencies in the time-series data. The input to the model consisted of historical node feature matrices encompassing traffic volume, vehicle speed, meteorological conditions, and past CO2 levels, while the output was the predicted CO2 concentration for each node across a 24-hour forecasting horizon.

The predictive outputs of the ST-GCN were subsequently integrated into a high-fidelity Digital Twin environment to facilitate proactive optimization. The Digital Twin was instantiated using the Simulation of Urban MObility (SUMO) microscopic traffic simulator, which was rigorously calibrated using the real-world IoT traffic and emission data to ensure a deviation of less than 5% from actual urban dynamics. Within this virtual replica, a Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) agent, specifically utilizing the Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) algorithm, was deployed to optimize traffic signal control dynamically. The optimization problem was formulated as a Markov Decision Process (MDP), where the state space incorporated both real-time traffic metrics (e.g., queue lengths, waiting times) and the forward-looking CO_2 predictions generated by the ST-GCN. The action space consisted of adjusting the duration of green phases for each traffic light controller, while the reward function was meticulously designed to balance environmental and operational objectives: it penalized high predicted CO_2 concentrations and excessive vehicle queues, while simultaneously rewarding the maximization of overall traffic throughput. By utilizing the predictive ST-GCN states rather than relying solely on reactive current states, the DRL agent could anticipate emission spikes and preemptively alter traffic signal timings to mitigate congestion-induced pollution before it materialized.

The experimental setup and model training were executed using a distributed computing environment equipped with NVIDIA A100 GPUs, utilizing the PyTorch framework for deep learning and the SUMO-RL interface for reinforcement learning interactions. The six-month dataset was partitioned chronologically into training (four months), validation (one month), and testing (one month) sets to prevent data leakage and ensure robust evaluation. The ST-GCN model was trained using the Adam optimizer with a learning rate of 0.001 and a batch size of 64, employing an early stopping mechanism based on validation loss to prevent overfitting. Concurrently, the PPO agent was trained over 10,000 episodes within the SUMO Digital Twin environment, utilizing experience replay and generalized advantage estimation to stabilize the learning process. To rigorously evaluate the framework, the predictive performance of the ST-GCN was benchmarked against established baseline models, including Autoregressive Integrated Moving Average (ARIMA), standalone Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks, and standard GCN models without temporal components, utilizing metrics such as Root Mean Square Error (RMSE), Mean Absolute Error (MAE), and the coefficient of determination (R^2). Furthermore, the efficacy of the predictive optimization was assessed by comparing the DRL-driven traffic signal control against traditional fixed-time actuated control and reactive RL baselines, measuring the percentage reduction in cumulative CO_2 emissions, average vehicle delay, and network-wide throughput during peak and off-peak hours.

3 Results

The predictive performance of the proposed Spatiotemporal Graph Convolutional Network (ST-GCN) was rigorously evaluated against three baseline models: Autoregressive Integrated Moving Average (ARIMA), standalone Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM), and a standard Graph Convolutional Network (GCN) lacking temporal components. Over the one-month testing period, the ST-GCN model demonstrated superior accuracy in forecasting 24-hour CO_2 concentration trajectories across the urban road network. Specifically, the ST-GCN achieved a Root Mean Square Error (RMSE) of 4.82 ppm and a Mean Absolute Error (MAE) of 3.15 ppm, alongside a coefficient of determination (R^2) of 0.94. Compared to the LSTM baseline, which yielded an RMSE of 6.29 ppm, the ST-GCN improved predictive accuracy by 23.4%. Furthermore, it outperformed the standard GCN (RMSE: 5.85 ppm) by 17.6% and the traditional ARIMA model (RMSE: 9.41 ppm) by 48.8%. A concrete example of this superiority was observed during a sudden, unpredicted traffic congestion event on a major arterial route on May 12th. While the ARIMA and standard GCN models failed to capture the rapid spatial propagation of the emission spike to downwind intersections due to their inability to model dynamic wind-adjusted adjacency, the ST-GCN accurately predicted the CO_2 surge at downstream nodes up to 45 minutes in advance, effectively capturing the non-linear spatiotemporal dependencies inherent in the urban environment. Building upon these high-fidelity predictions, the integration of the ST-GCN outputs into the SUMO-based

Digital Twin environment enabled the Deep Reinforcement Learning (DRL) agent, utilizing the Proximal Policy Optimization (PPO) algorithm, to execute predictive traffic signal optimization. The optimization efficacy was assessed by comparing the proposed predictive DRL agent against two baselines: a traditional fixed-time actuated control system and a reactive DRL agent that optimizes signals based solely on current traffic states without forward-looking emission predictions. During the peak-hour simulation scenarios, the predictive DRL agent achieved an 18.7% reduction in cumulative CO_2 emissions compared to the fixed-time baseline. Crucially, this environmental benefit was achieved while maintaining overall network traffic throughput within 2.8% of the baseline levels, ensuring that emission reductions did not come at the cost of severe traffic congestion. In contrast, the reactive DRL agent only achieved a 9.4% emission reduction and occasionally caused localized queue spillbacks by over-optimizing for immediate intersection clearance. A specific operational example occurred at a complex five-way intersection in the city center during the evening rush hour. The predictive DRL agent, anticipating a high-emission influx from a nearby stadium event based on ST-GCN forecasts, preemptively extended the green phase for the egress routes by 14 seconds. This proactive adjustment prevented the formation of a stagnant, high-idling traffic queue, thereby avoiding an estimated 4.2 kg of excess CO_2 emissions that would have occurred under the reactive control strategy. Finally, the computational efficiency of the proposed IoT and edge-assisted architecture was evaluated against a traditional cloud-only processing paradigm. The deployment of lightweight anomaly detection and initial data aggregation at the 150 edge nodes significantly alleviated the bandwidth burden on the central cloud platform. Network telemetry recorded a 62% reduction in data transmission latency, decreasing the average round-trip time from 145 ms in the cloud-only setup to 55 ms in the edge-assisted framework. This near-real-time responsiveness is critical for the Digital Twin, as it ensures that the ST-GCN model receives synchronized, high-fidelity data streams without delay, which in turn allows the PPO agent to execute signal adjustments with minimal lag. While the edge nodes incurred a marginal increase in local computational overhead, consuming approximately 18% of the available CPU capacity on the IoT gateways, this trade-off was highly favorable compared to the severe latency penalties and cloud processing bottlenecks experienced during peak data ingestion periods. Overall, the results confirm that the synergistic integration of edge computing, ST-GCN predictive modeling, and Digital Twin optimization provides a robust, highly responsive, and environmentally effective framework for smart city carbon management.

5 Conclusion

This study presented a novel, IoT-enabled Digital Twin framework integrated with Spatiotemporal Graph Convolutional Networks and Deep Reinforcement Learning for the predictive modeling and proactive optimization of urban carbon emissions. The empirical validation demonstrated that the proposed architecture successfully bridges the critical gap between static, retrospective environmental monitoring and dynamic, real-time urban management. By explicitly modeling the non-Euclidean spatial dependencies of the road network and the temporal evolution of traffic-induced pollution, the ST-GCN model achieved superior predictive accuracy, significantly outperforming traditional statistical and standard deep learning baselines. Furthermore, the integration of these high-fidelity predictions into the Digital Twin environment enabled the reinforcement learning agent to execute preemptive traffic signal optimizations, yielding a substantial reduction in peak-hour carbon emissions without compromising overall network throughput. The deployment of edge computing within the IoT infrastructure further ensured the low-latency data processing required for near-real-time decision-making, proving the technical feasibility and operational efficiency of the proposed system.

The broader implications of this research extend beyond mere technical advancements, offering a transformative paradigm for smart city environmental governance. By shifting the focus from passive observation to active, predictive intervention, the framework provides city planners and policymakers with a scalable, data-driven tool to mitigate urban pollution dynamically. This proactive approach directly supports the achievement of Sustainable Development Goals, particularly SDG 11 (Sustainable Cities and Communities) and SDG 13 (Climate Action), by enabling cities to optimize existing infrastructure rather than relying solely on costly physical expansions or rigid regulatory measures. The methodology is inherently flexible and can be adapted to manage other complex urban environmental challenges, such as localized air quality degradation, energy grid load balancing, and noise pollution control.

Despite the promising outcomes, certain limitations of this study must be acknowledged to guide future research. First, the framework was validated using data from a single mid-sized European city, which may limit the immediate generalizability of the model to megacities with vastly different topological structures, traffic behaviors, and meteorological conditions. Second, while the Digital Twin simulation provided a highly calibrated and realistic environment for training the reinforcement learning agent, the optimization strategies have not yet been deployed in a live, physical traffic control system, where unpredictable human driver behavior and legacy infrastructure constraints could introduce unforeseen variables. Future research should therefore prioritize multi-city, cross-regional validations to enhance the model's robustness and generalizability. Additionally, subsequent studies should focus on real-world pilot deployments to evaluate the practical efficacy of the predictive control algorithms in live urban environments. Expanding the framework to incorporate multi-pollutant modeling, including PM2.5 and NOx, and integrating the dynamics of electric vehicle charging networks and micro-mobility will further enrich the Digital Twin, ultimately paving the way for truly holistic, zero-emission smart cities.

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